

and have a neon sign highlighting the price. Again, buyer beware: Check the original price and compare it to other similar products. Often the items displayed on gondolas are actually more expensive, be they on sale or not. Only after some due diligence should you decide if that pretty pyramid of product is really meant to compliment your shopping cart.

4. "Complementation"—the ultimate distraction

Coffee or tea is on your list. And before you know it, a package of yummy-looking biscuits that are temptingly displayed next to the coffee and tea is also in your cart. Then you head for the pasta aisle, and walk out with an overpriced pesto sauce that simply looked too good to resist. Be wary of items which complement each other that are positioned near one another in the supermarket. If you aren't the sort to rigidly stick to a list, complementary items will jump off the shelves and into your cart before you know what happened.

5. Watch the checkout like a hawk

You may not remember the exact prices for everything that is in your cart, but you likely have a good idea

of what you will be charged, especially if you picked up a few sale items and are proud of it. But upon reaching the checkout, you could well discover that those items you thought were on sale are not scanning through as such—either because the actual sale item was next to or below the one you picked up (a very sly maneuver on the part of grocery stores), or because the scanner codes were "accidentally" never adjusted.

If there is a huge line behind you and you don't want to cause a stir with the checkout clerk (who will likely have to call for assistance and stare belligerently at you while you both wait for somebody to run around the store doing price checks), then simply march your items and receipt up to customer service and politely point out the discrepancy.

6. Try a cupboard special

After reading this, are you angry at supermarkets for their little ploys and marketing decoys? Great! Skip your next scheduled trip to the supermarket! See what you can scrounge up from the dark corners of your cupboards or frost-bitten freezer, and get creative. Some of my best meals have been dubbed "cupboard specials," making use of what I have on hand when supplies start to dwindle. —Nora Dunn